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Prompt 4

The Normativity of The Anyone

In his 1927 book *Being and Time*, Martin Heidegger proposes a radically novel ontology that diverges from the philosophical tradition of the subject-object ontology. In this book, Heidegger introduces the social structure of being that he refers to as "the Anyone." Although the phenomenon of the Anyone may be analyzed as lowering Dasein's degree of being, the the establishment of Dasein as the Anyone as described by Heidegger contains no traces of this value judgement, and rather highlights the necessity of including the structure of the Anyone in this ontology, with the utilization of connotatively inflammatory terminology conveying a meta-linguistic point about the influence and pervasiveness of the Anyone. I seek to emphasize the category error in placing value judgements on the Anyone or any ontological structure given by Heidegger while also justifying the importance of the Anyone in a complete ontology. First, I will explain Heidegger's ontological structure up to the introduction of the Anyone, including all necessary definitions. Next, I will iterate over Heidegger's introduction of the Anyone and why such a structure is necessary to his ontology as a whole. Using this ontology, I will then argue that the interpretation of the Anyone conveyed through the prior definitions and precision of Heidegger escapes the classification of value judgements, and rather all qualities of the Anyone contribute to a richer understanding of authenticity and being.

Heidegger coins or appropriates novel terminology and definitions throughout his ontology in order to differentiate it from the ontology of the philosophical tradition. The first of these terms is "Dasein," which is introduced as the being for whom being is an issue, or, put simply, 'I.' Dasein exists in a gestalt holism of references and relationships between things and their purposes. As a part of this referential totality, the use of these things by Dasein for Dasein's projects is also contained. When Dasein utilizes familiar equipment, the equipment fades into the background of perception as ready-to-hand while focus is placed on the process of the project. Alternatively, when an issue arises within Dasein's project, the equipment is scrutinized as present-at-hand. Furthermore, Other Dasein are part of the referential totality – Dasein is surrounded by equipment and Others. Encountering things that refer to Others, such as a boat belonging to Others, is an ontological structure referred to as Dasein-with. The Other is encountered in Dasein-with the world – the world of involvement always references Others. The second mode of being that relates Dasein to Others is Being-with, which is the encounter of Others in the world, concretely. In Being-with Others, Dasein creates structures to distance itself from the Others. To know oneself is to assume the self to not be the other (§26).

Heidegger introduces the Anyone as the third ontological structure representing Dasein encountering other Dasein in the average everydayness of being. The existence of the Anyone stems from the inherent sociality of Dasein. The Anyone is an essential part of Dasein that prescribes the kind of being of everydayness. The Anyone is the social, cultural, linguistic, epistemological, et cetera norms that limit the possibilities of Dasein in its everydayness. It is not a single Dasein, not some Dasein or a sum of all Dasein, but a dissolution of one's self into being "of the Others." For example, suppose I wanted to dye my hair pink, and my mother says "What will people say?" The 'people' referenced by my mother is the Anyone. Just as equipment fades

into the background in its everydayness as ready-to-hand, the self fades into the background in its everydayness as the Anyone. This is not to say that the self is not present-at-hand; The self is always present-at-hand but not always attended to as present-at-hand. Inauthenticity is this non-attention of the self, this giving up of one's own otherness to the Others – a distantiality of the self from the self. As the Anyone, Dasein loses itself to inauthenticity when Being-with others and becomes nobody. This Anyone-self, however, is the necessary component from which the self can be discovered, for the inauthentic Anyone-self is the basis for the authentic self. In keeping with the past structures, the self of Dasein experiences things which are not the self that allow what it means to be the self. To know oneself assumes one is not an other self. Being-with others is the way that Dasein understands itself in its solitude, and thus the authentic self is defined as an existentiell modification of the Anyone (§27).

Referring to the ontological phenomenon of the Anyone from an ontological position with the adjectives of 'positive' and 'negative' as synonymous to 'good' and 'bad' is a category error in the interpretation of the phenomenon as ontological. These ontical descriptors remain for the ontic. Furthermore, the assigning of 'negativity' with such concepts (and I say concepts, not words) as "domination," "dictatorship," and "levelling down" reveals the societal and therefore personal connotations with such terms, as moral judgements validated by the 'Anyone' in both the public ontological dichotomy of good and bad, as well as the subject-object ontology of the philosophical tradition with 'goodness' or 'badness' stemming from effects on the subject. Heidegger's ontology has no place for these conceptions of positive and negative, as they are rooted in the aforementioned misled ontology of the tradition. For if Heidegger is to be interpreted more accurately, the correct terminology for assessing the phenomenon of the Anyone is as a spectrum of publicness constituted by "distantiality," "averageness," and

“levelling-down” (§27). The Anyone is not to be assessed as positive versus deficient, as inspired by the modes of solicitude, and certainly not positive versus negative. Furthermore, the Anyone does result in domination and dictatorship, and is a constitutive structure of Dasein’s existence. These modes of being are not a result of a deficiency or surplus of the Anyone or a value judgement of it, but rather ever-present characteristics of Dasein that come from the mere existence of the Anyone. To interpret the negativity of the Anyone as domination and dictatorship, and the positivity of the Anyone as constitutive for being, would be inconsistent with the ontological terminology. Positivity in this conceptual scheme means a characterization by presence, thus both of these claims correlate to a positivity of the Anyone. Additionally, there cannot be a negativity or neutrality of the Anyone, for the Anyone is an essential part of Dasein which can only be modified, not detached or escaped. Heidegger exhibits control and precision over his terminology as a necessity for his project against the tradition.